

A leaking keyboard

In what looks like an amazing security goof up, an HP wireless keyboard user in Norway discovered that what he typed into his screen appeared on a friend's monitor, some 150 metres away—supposedly far out of range and blocked by at least two solid walls. With HP and the user initially



assuming that this was a one-off fault with that particular keyboard, they settled on a replacement. Even after replacement, the keyboard signals still reach across 150 metres! HP is now considering doing field tests to ascertain the reasons behind it.

HP has sold some 65,000 wireless keyboards in Europe and a smaller number in North America. What is worrying is the fact that such a strong signal gives the users no control over who receives it, compromising on their security. Already, it is possible to illegally intercept signals emitted from them, but in this case, the device is literally beaming the signals far and wide, singing away to all and sundry!

snapshot

\$4 billion worth of Linux servers expected to sell in 2003, shipping about **8 lakh** units

Source: Gartner Dataquest

followup

Symantec deletes more than spam

Users of Symantec's Norton Internet Security 2003 have discovered that the software causes e-mail to be deleted before it reaches the user's inbox. Symantec says that the flaw comes from the anti-spam feature in the software that tags suspected spam, and has fixed the problem with a patch. If the user had a large volume of mail arriving or if the client was frequently checking e-mail, then Norton Spam Alert would cause mem-



Illustrations: Farzana Cooper

ory allocation errors that lead to e-mail deletions. For such e-mail, all that appeared in the inbox was a cryptic

message with 'Symantec E-mail Proxy Deleted Message' in the subject line.

The problem faced by Norton's customers is similar to what many Hotmail account users face, with strict spam filters in place. Hotmail follows a very strict policy of blocking all the mail from offending ISPs.

Blockbusters on the Net

You could soon be buying and legally downloading movies from the Internet, or so hope five of the major studios in Hollywood. Sony Pic-



tures, MGM, Paramount Pictures, Warner Brothers and Universal Pictures have joined together and announced technology partnerships with Microsoft and RealNetworks to jumpstart movie-rental services on the Net. Industry executives are ecstatic at what they call the bounty of video-on-demand. Moreover, distribution is planned to be secure and unbreachable. You can now download over 175 new and old movies from movielink.com. The movies, of course, don't come for free—you are required to pay anywhere between \$1.99 (approx Rs 100) and \$4.99 (approx Rs 250), depending on how new

the movie is. Once downloaded, it will remain for 30 days on the hard drive, though once you have started to play the movie it will remain only for 24 hours. Moreover, it cannot be transferred to any other device, and this they hope will curb trading of movies over the Internet via P2P networks such as KaZaA and Morpheus. This service is operational only in the US right now and dial-up users are strongly discouraged. While it is an interesting concept, it does have its problems. Firstly, you could rent DVDs and keep them for at least two nights for the same price. Moreover, even with broadband connections, it could take up to 4 hours for a single download. On the other hand, code hackers aren't keeping quiet—pirates are already talking about circumventing these measures. They claim that unless the movie 'self destructs', there is every possibility that a solution could be found!



heroes

Supercomputing

On November 4, more than 1,000 computers across Canada were wired up to create a huge networked supercomputer, used to model the interaction of two molecules in 20,000 different positions and measure the energy bonds which this creates—a single desktop would take over six years for this.

Tablet PC

Microsoft has signed deals with top publishers *Forbes*, *Financial Times*, *New Yorker*, *Slate*, *France's Les Echos* and Germany's *Wirtschafts Woche* to help make the Tablet PC more popular. A trial set of the magazines should be available for download in 2003.



zeroes

Digital voting

America is pioneering digital voting, but security challenges seem far too many. Large-scale fraud, like vote-buying and selling, are simpler on a computer that is vulnerable to hackers and viruses. Moreover, the software used for voting purposes is proprietary and the vendors control it, leaving its accuracy to question.

Philanthropy

PowerUp, a three-year-old project that gave away computer equipment to schools and community centres across the United States has been shut down. The weakening economy has forced its founders to close down the program aimed at bridging the great digital divide.